We met days later for another dinner.

As it happened, her flatmate was dating my longtime mate Charlie. Brother of my late friend Henners.

I joked: *Obviously this is meant to be. The four of us could have so much fun*.

But I wasn't totally joking.

We tried another kiss. Not so awkward.

I had hope.

For our next date she and her flatmate had Charlie and me over. Drinks, laughs. Before I knew what was happening, we were a thing.

Sadly, however, I could only see Cress at weekends. I was busier than ever, doing my final preps for deployment. And then I got my official orders, my actual deployment date, and the clock was now loudly ticking. For the second time in my life I needed to tell a young woman I'd just met that I'd soon be going off to war.

I'll wait, she said. *But not forever*, she added quickly. *Who knows what's going to happen, Haz?*

Right. Who knows?

Easier to just tell myself, and others, that we're not together.

Yes. That is easier, I suppose.

But when you're back…

When. She'd said *when.* Not *if.*

I was grateful.

Some people said if.

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MY MATES CAME TO me and reminded me of the Plan.

The Plan?

You know, Spike. The Plan?